



THE ADVENTURER'S GUILD

QUEST REWARD GUIDE

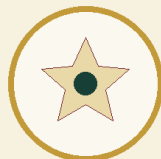
Questmaster Handbook for Dungeon Masters

A campaign-facing system for setting fair contract pay, Quest Points, reputation, treasure, favors, and consequences in D&D 5e and the revised 5e rules commonly called 5.5e.

THE FIVE FORMS OF A COMPLETE REWARD



COIN



QUEST POINTS



REPUTATION



TREASURE



ACCESS & FAVORS

Reward the deed, advance the story, and preserve the value of what comes next.

QUESTMASTER'S MAXIM *Pay enough that the work matters, not so much that nothing else does. The best reward changes what the party can attempt next.*

Primary audience: Dungeon Masters, Questmasters, and campaign administrators.

Player-facing quest notices should reveal only the terms that the characters are entitled to know.

A NOTICE FROM THE QUESTMASTER-GENERAL

Dungeon Master,

A posted reward is more than a number beside a quest. It tells the players what the Guild values, how dangerous the work is believed to be, who can afford justice, and what kinds of power exist in the world. Once announced, the terms become a promise. Once paid, the reward becomes part of the campaign's economy and the party's future capability.

Use this guide before a quest is offered, not only after it is completed. Decide what success means, what the client can pay, what the Guild will subsidize, and which rewards should remain hidden until earned. Then record the decision so that similar work receives similar treatment.

The tables in this handbook are campaign tools, not replacements for the treasure, item, or advancement rules printed in an approved sourcebook. When an official item or rule is used, the Dungeon Master should verify it in the physical book available at the table and record the edition being used.

— **Ilyra Voss**

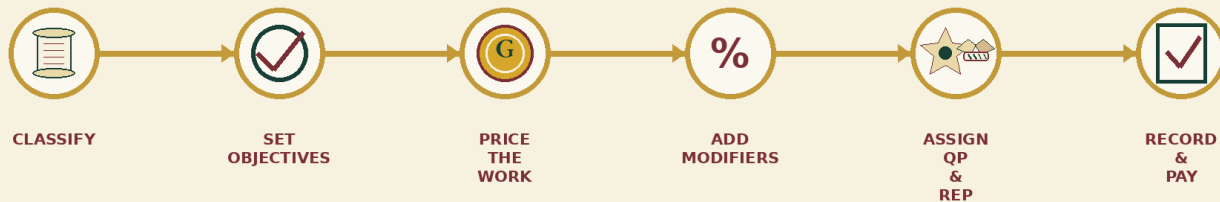
Questmaster-General, Office of Contracts and Quest Administration

DUNGEON MASTER PRINCIPLE *Rewards should be predictable enough to feel fair, varied enough to remain exciting, and flexible enough to serve the story.*

What This Guide Provides

A COMMON LANGUAGE Guild ranks, quest classifications, objective tiers, payout stages, and ownership categories.	PRACTICAL BENCHMARKS Coin ranges, Quest Point awards, reputation gains, modifiers, and treasure guidance.
FAILURE PROCEDURES Partial success, honest failure, abandonment, client breach, disputed terms, and compensation.	DM WORKSHEETS Pre-posting checklist, reward worksheet, payout ledger, and worked examples for common quest types.

THE QUESTMASTER'S REWARD PROCESS



1. CAMPAIGN AUTHORITY AND REWARD PHILOSOPHY

The Dungeon Master Is the Final Authority

This guide standardizes decisions; it does not surrender them. The Dungeon Master may adjust any recommendation for campaign tone, regional wealth, party composition, character needs, narrative consequence, or the requirements of an approved adventure. Make the adjustment deliberately and note the reason when it creates a precedent.

Approved Rules and Physical Sources

- Players and Dungeon Masters may use officially licensed D&D 5e or revised 5e/5.5e material that is available in a physical book owned by a participant at the table.
- Record the source title and rules version for any magic item, spell-based service, vehicle, or reward whose operation matters during play.
- When 2014 and revised rules differ, choose one version for the specific reward and use it consistently. Do not combine favorable fragments from both versions unless the Dungeon Master intentionally creates a house rule.
- Third-party, partnered, promotional, digital-only, playtest, and homebrew rewards require explicit Dungeon Master approval before appearing on a quest notice or treasure list.

Five Principles of Good Reward Design

1. Clarity: the party can tell what must be accomplished and which terms are guaranteed, conditional, negotiable, or secret.
2. Proportion: the reward reflects expected danger, time, scarcity, political burden, and campaign tier without trivializing future rewards.
3. Variety: coin is useful, but reputation, information, access, consumables, property, and personal opportunities keep rewards meaningful.
4. Consequence: rewards create choices, obligations, relationships, and new capabilities rather than existing only as accounting.
5. Consistency: comparable work receives comparable treatment unless the difference is an intentional fact about the world.

DO NOT PRICE HUMAN WORTH *Quest classification measures the operation, not the value of the victim, settlement, or client. A poor village may require Guild subsidy; it should not receive less protection because it cannot pay.*

The Three Reward Horizons

Horizon	Typical Frequency	Best Uses
Session	Most sessions	Small coin, expenses, consumables, clues, contacts, immediate relief.
Quest	At completion or major milestone	Contract pay, Quest Points, reputation, choice of service, meaningful treasure.
Arc	At a major turning point	Permanent magic items, titles, property, faction authority, rare knowledge, world change.

2. BUILDING A COMPLETE REWARD PACKAGE

A reward package is the full set of benefits and consequences attached to a quest. Most quests should use at least two forms of reward. Major quests should usually use three or more, with one element that is not simply money.

The Five Reward Forms

Reward Form	What It Does	Use It When
Coin and valuables	Funds equipment, services, travel, lifestyle, crafting, and player-directed plans.	The client can pay, the Guild can subsidize, or recovered valuables may lawfully be claimed.
Quest Points (QP)	Advances standing in the Adventurer's Guild and buys Guild-controlled benefits.	The quest is officially registered and the party fulfilled a meaningful Guild obligation.
Reputation	Changes how a person, settlement, faction, or institution treats the party.	Witnesses care about the outcome, the beneficiary remembers it, or the deed becomes known.
Treasure and items	Adds capability, flexibility, identity, or a new tactical option.	The item is discoverable, granted, commissioned, inherited, or authorized as a Guild award.
Access, favors, and story rewards	Opens doors that coin cannot: audiences, training, titles, land, secrets, permits, allies.	The quest changes relationships or proves the party worthy of trust.

Guaranteed, Conditional, and Hidden Terms

GUARANTEED Paid when the stated minimum objective is met. Keep this wording plain and enforce it consistently.	CONDITIONAL Paid only for a named secondary objective, deadline, quality standard, capture, rescue, or preservation requirement.
REIMBURSABLE Necessary expenses covered up to a stated limit, with receipts, witnesses, or reasonable evidence where practical.	HIDDEN A surprise reward based on discovery, gratitude, faction response, treasure, or exceptional conduct. Never use a hidden term to reduce promised pay.

A Useful Default Mix

- Routine quest: coin + 1 QP or a small reputation gain.
- Standard adventure: coin + QP + reputation or consumable treasure.
- Major quest: coin + QP + reputation + one story or item reward.
- Arc conclusion: a layered package with player choice, permanent consequence, and at least one reward that creates the next opportunity.

THE REWARD SHOULD POINT FORWARD *Ask what the party can now attempt, whom they can now approach, and what new problem their reward might create.*

3. GUILD QUEST CLASSIFICATION



Classify the quest according to the danger and operational burden reasonably expected when the notice is posted. The classification is not a guarantee. Discovering that the Guild was wrong may justify additional pay, evacuation, reclassification, or a new contract.

Class	Operational Meaning	Common Features	Authorization
Green	Routine, local, or low-risk work.	Nuisance removal, delivery, observation, simple escort, property issue; combat not expected.	Open to qualified members, often Bronze.
Yellow	Meaningful danger or uncertainty.	Rescue, investigation, dangerous beast, minor hostile force, hazardous terrain, one serious encounter.	Party leader or Questmaster review.
Orange	Serious operation with multiple failure points.	Multiple encounters, hostile territory, time pressure, regional consequence, difficult recovery.	Rank-appropriate approval and operational plan.
Red	Critical threat with likely casualties if mishandled.	Powerful enemy, mass danger, restricted magic, political crisis, siege, disaster response.	Senior Questmaster, faction leader, or Council authority.
Black	Catastrophic, existential, or fundamentally unknown.	World-scale threat, divine or planar danger, nation-breaking event, artifact-level consequence.	Guild Council and sovereign coordination whenever possible.

Classification Questions

☐ How many dangerous scenes or encounters are reasonably expected?

☐ What is the chance that a failed check creates injury, loss, capture, or escalation?

☐ How difficult is retreat, rescue, or resupply?

☐ What happens to bystanders or the region if the party fails?

☐ Does the operation require secrecy, nonlethal force, special law, or restricted magic?

☐ How accurate is the available intelligence?

RECLASSIFICATION *When the party uncovers a threat at least one full classification above the posting, pause when practical. Let them report, renegotiate, withdraw without dishonor, or accept the elevated risk knowingly.*

4. ESTABLISHING THE BASE COIN AWARD

The following ranges are campaign benchmarks for the total posted contract value paid to the party, not to each character. They assume a quest of ordinary duration for the listed classification and do not include reimbursed expenses, recovered lawful treasure, or separate patron gifts.

Guild Rank	Green	Yellow	Orange	Red	Black
Bronze (Lv. 1-4)	5-10 gp	10-25 gp	25-75 gp	75-200 gp	200-500 gp
Silver (Lv. 5-8)	50-100 gp	100-300 gp	300-750 gp	750-2,000 gp	2,000-5,000 gp
Gold (Lv. 9-12)	500-1,000 gp	1,000-3,000 gp	3,000-7,500 gp	7,500-20,000 gp	20,000-50,000 gp
Platinum (Lv. 13-16)	5,000-10,000 gp	10,000-30,000 gp	30,000-75,000 gp	75,000-200,000 gp	200,000-500,000 gp
Adamantine (Lv. 17-20)	25,000-50,000 gp	50,000-150,000 gp	150,000-400,000 gp	400,000-1,000,000 gp	1,000,000+ gp

CAMPAIGN BENCHMARK *These values support the Adventurer's Guild economy established for Oathbound. Adjust the entire table, not isolated rows, when the campaign uses a substantially richer or poorer economy.*

Selecting a Value Within the Range

- Use the low end for a brief, well-understood task near safe support and resupply.
- Use the middle for a normal quest with meaningful risk, travel, and at least one complication.
- Use the high end for poor intelligence, hard travel, several objectives, legal restrictions, unusual danger, or consequences beyond the immediate client.

Who Pays?

Payer	Best Practice
Private client	Use deposit or escrow for substantial contracts. Record what happens if the client withholds payment.
Settlement or government	Clarify whether payment is coin, tax relief, land, salvage rights, title, or institutional service.
The Guild	Use for public protection, impoverished clients, Guild priorities, emergency response, and classified operations.
Faction or patron	Expect reputation effects, obligations, secrecy terms, or political consequences.
Recovered value	State what may be kept, what belongs to the client, and what must be inventoried before division.

Do Not Let Coin Carry Every Reward

At higher ranks, increasing coin by another zero often matters less than access, ownership, authority, rare components, safe transportation, information, or the right to shape an institution. Use coin to support player plans; use other rewards to change the campaign.

5. MODIFIERS, EXPENSES, AND NEGOTIATION

Begin with the base coin range, then apply only the modifiers that represent burdens not already included in the classification. Avoid stacking several modifiers for the same underlying risk.

Modifier	Suggested Adjustment	When It Applies
Poor or false intelligence	+10% to +50%	The client or Guild cannot provide reliable location, numbers, defenses, or nature of the threat.
Severe time pressure	+10% to +50%	Delay materially worsens the outcome or the party must depart without ordinary preparation.
Remote travel or isolation	+10% to +25%	Resupply, retreat, communication, or rescue is unusually difficult.
Nonlethal or preservation requirement	+10% to +25%	The party must capture, protect evidence, avoid property damage, or preserve a creature or site.
Restricted magic or legal burden	+10% to +50%	The operation requires permits, witnesses, containment, special handling, or personal legal exposure.
Public danger or mass evacuation	+25% to +100%	The party must protect many civilians while completing the objective.
Exceptional secrecy	+10% to +25%	The party cannot seek ordinary aid, reveal its purpose, or publicly claim credit.
Client-caused hazard	As restitution	The client concealed a material risk or violated the agreed terms.

Expenses

- Ordinary personal gear and routine upkeep are normally the adventurer's responsibility.
- Quest-specific permits, specialized transport, consumables demanded by the client, and replacement of authorized expendable Guild property should normally be reimbursed or issued directly.
- Set a preapproved limit for discretionary expenses. Require an explanation, not modern paperwork, when receipts would be implausible in-world.
- Do not use reimbursement to conceal the actual reward. Expense coverage returns the party to where it began; reward compensates it for the work and risk.

Negotiation Procedure

1. Establish what the client and Questmaster know, want, fear, and can afford.
2. Identify which terms are firm because of law, scarcity, policy, or urgency.
3. Allow the party to trade between coin, deadline, scope, secrecy, expenses, salvage rights, and noncash benefits when reasonable.
4. Record the final terms before departure. A successful negotiation should change the contract, not merely produce a larger number without explanation.

NEVER PUNISH ENGAGEMENT *Players who ask sensible questions or negotiate in good faith are engaging with the world. Reward that engagement with information and meaningful choices, even when the client cannot increase the pay.*

6. QUEST POINT AWARDS

Quest Points represent recognized service to the Adventurer's Guild. They are awarded to each participating member unless a campaign rule states otherwise. QP are not coin, are not normally transferable, and should not be reduced merely because a client is poor.

Classification	Base QP per Member	Typical Use
Green	1 QP	Routine service that is properly completed and reported.
Yellow	2 QP	Meaningful risk, rescue, investigation, or protection.
Orange	3 QP	Serious multi-stage operation or regional danger.
Red	5 QP	Critical service with major personal or public risk.
Black	8 QP	Catastrophic or world-defining operation; 10-12 QP may be suitable for an arc-ending achievement.

Objective Bonuses

- Award +1 QP for a difficult optional objective that materially improves the outcome.
- Award +1 QP for exceptional Guild service: preserving lives at meaningful cost, returning vital intelligence, exposing corruption, or preventing a greater crisis.
- Do not award bonus QP for ordinary competence already required by the quest.
- As a default, bonus QP should not exceed half the base award. Arc finales and singular achievements may exceed this limit deliberately.

Partial and Individual QP

Situation	Recommended Treatment
Character participated in the meaningful portion	Award the normal QP unless absence was voluntary and materially reduced contribution.
Character joined late or departed early for real-world reasons	Do not use QP to punish attendance problems. Resolve scheduling socially, not through character advancement.
Character refused the Guild objective	Withhold or reduce QP only when the refusal was a character choice that meaningfully opposed the registered mission.
Party achieved a legitimate alternate solution	Award full QP when the actual need was met, even if the method differed from the expected plan.
Quest failed despite good-faith professional conduct	Award 0-50% of base QP for valuable service, rescue, intelligence, or prevention of worse harm.

QP TRACKS SERVICE, NOT KILLS *Do not tie Quest Points to enemy count, combat participation, or damage. Negotiation, investigation, rescue, restraint, and retreat can fulfill the Guild mission.*

7. REPUTATION, RENOWN, AND PUBLIC CREDIT

Reputation answers a different question than Quest Points: not what the Guild records, but who now knows and cares. Track reputation separately for important settlements, factions, patrons, communities, and institutions.

Gain	Meaning	Examples
0	No meaningful change	The deed was routine, secret, unnoticed, or unrelated to the faction.
+1	Favorable notice	The party kept a promise, solved a local problem, or treated people well.
+2	Significant trust	The party accepted real cost, protected the faction, or delivered a major success.
+3	Transformative deed	The party saved the faction from disaster, changed its future, or became a defining ally.
-1 to -3	Loss of trust	Breach, cruelty, public failure, betrayal, avoidable collateral harm, or opposing faction interests.

Suggested Standing Bands

Score	Standing	Likely Effects
0	Unknown	Normal prices, limited access, no special presumption of trust.
1-4	Known	Recognized name, minor courtesies, basic introductions, better information.
5-9	Trusted	Private audiences, fair credit, modest aid, faction-specific opportunities.
10-19	Honored	Priority help, sensitive work, training, rare services, public support.
20-34	Champion	Authority to speak, mobilize resources, request major favors, shape policy.
35+	Pillar or Legend	The party is part of the faction's identity; rewards and consequences become political and historic.

Public Credit Is a Reward Choice

- Public praise increases reputation but may reveal methods, enemies, possessions, and affiliations.
- Secret service may earn greater private access or favor instead of public renown.
- Let the party decide whether to accept credit when the world permits a choice.
- A faction may claim credit unfairly, suppress the truth, or rewrite the story. Treat that as a consequence and future hook, not a bookkeeping error.

TRACK RELATIONSHIPS, NOT POPULARITY *Reputation should reflect what a specific group believes the party has done and what that group values. The same deed can earn +2 with one faction and -1 with another.*

8. TREASURE, MAGIC ITEMS, AND CONSUMABLE REWARDS

Treasure should be placed with purpose. Decide whether the item is contract payment, Guild issue, client property, lawful salvage, hidden discovery, enemy equipment, or story inheritance. Ownership and source matter as much as rarity.

Guild Rank	Routine Treasure	Major or Arc Reward
Bronze	Useful mundane gear, common consumables, temporary boons, small caches.	An uncommon permanent item as a deliberate milestone or strongly themed discovery.
Silver	Common and uncommon consumables; occasional uncommon permanent items.	A rare item at a major turning point, or a choice among several uncommon options.
Gold	Uncommon consumables; rare items tied to specialization or story.	A very rare item for a major arc, institution, or singular achievement.
Platinum	Rare consumables and very rare items with clear narrative weight.	A legendary item only when the campaign is ready for its consequences.
Adamantine	Very rare and legendary rewards shaped by world-scale play.	Artifacts and unique relics must be story-defining, not routine payment.

Permanent Items

- Prefer items that create options, identity, or adventure hooks over items that merely increase a number the character already excels at.
- Consider party fit, attunement pressure, duplicate functions, action economy, and whether the item invalidates a recurring challenge too early.
- Offer meaningful choice when no single recipient is obvious: several items, a commissioning right, a Guild credit, or a chance to research what the party wants.
- Record the physical sourcebook and rules version for every official item. Homebrew items should have a complete written entry approved before use.

Consumables and Limited Rewards

- Consumables allow generous treasure without permanently increasing every later encounter.
- Limited charges, single-use favors, temporary access, maps, keys, tokens, and time-bound blessings encourage players to make choices.
- Do not make every useful reward too precious to use. Players should reasonably expect more opportunities to obtain consumable support.

TREASURE IS NOT AUTOMATICALLY PROPERTY *Finding an item does not settle ownership. Sacred objects, stolen goods, evidence, commissioned cargo, and identifiable heirlooms may belong to someone else. Make the distinction clear enough to become a choice.*

9. SERVICES, FAVORS, TITLES, AND ACCESS

Noncash rewards often remain meaningful after ordinary coin stops feeling scarce. They also show the party that institutions and relationships have changed because of what the characters accomplished.

GUILD SERVICES Identification, secure storage, research assistance, translation, legal support, transport, healing, restoration, training, crafting access, or equipment requisition.	POLITICAL ACCESS An audience, letter of passage, permit, diplomatic protection, restricted archive, military escort, right to petition, or authority to act in a defined matter.
PROPERTY AND BASE SUPPORT Rooms, workshop access, land, a guild office, maintenance assistance, staff, tax relief, construction materials, or protection for a headquarters.	PERSONAL OPPORTUNITIES A mentor, apprenticeship, family answer, restored name, faction initiation, custom commission, invitation, or lead connected to a character goal.
INFORMATION A true map, enemy identity, hidden history, secure route, prophecy fragment, witness, password, or answer that changes the party's plans.	FAVORS OWED A defined service from a named person or faction. State who owes it, what limits exist, and whether asking will create a new obligation.

Valuing a Favor

Tier	Examples	DM Guidance
Minor	Introduction, simple paperwork, routine research, local lodging, ordinary transport.	Useful now; should not bypass a major obstacle.
Significant	Rare service, restricted audience, costly legal help, specialized team, dangerous transport.	Comparable to a substantial quest reward and likely remembered.
Major	Military intervention, sovereign protection, resurrection-level service, institutional policy change.	Should alter an arc and create obligations or political consequences.
Historic	A kingdom mobilizes, a planar gate opens, an ancient order reveals its final secret.	Use only when the party has earned world-shaping influence.

Write the Limits

- A favor without limits becomes either useless because players fear spending it or overwhelming because no boundary exists.
- Define the debtor, scope, urgency, geographic reach, moral limits, expiration if any, and what happens when the request would endanger the debtor.

ACCESS CAN BE THE REAL TREASURE *The right door, the right name, or the right permission can be more valuable than a chest of gold and far more connected to the world.*

10. OBJECTIVES, PARTIAL SUCCESS, FAILURE, AND BONUS PAY

Write Objectives Before Play

Objective Type	Purpose	Example
Primary	Defines the minimum condition for completing the contract.	Locate the missing trapper and return with a verified report.
Secondary	Improves the result but is not required for basic completion.	Recover the trapper's maps and intact equipment.
Protection	Limits collateral harm or preserves something important.	Do not kill the white stag or damage the orchard.
Time	Creates urgency or changes later events.	Complete the evacuation before the river reaches flood stage.
Discovery	Rewards investigation beyond the obvious task.	Determine who placed the false trail markers and why.
Secret	Known only to the DM, patron, faction, or hidden client.	Confirm whether the ruins contain evidence of forbidden magic.

Recommended Payout by Outcome

Outcome	Coin	QP	Reputation and Consequences
Complete success	100% guaranteed pay plus earned bonuses.	Full base QP plus earned bonuses.	Apply the intended positive changes.
Partial success	50-90% according to the benefit actually delivered.	Usually 50-100% if meaningful service was completed.	Mixed gain, limited benefit, unresolved threat, or new obligation.
Honest failure	0-25% pay or expense coverage when useful service or rescue occurred.	0-50% for intelligence, prevention of worse harm, or professional conduct.	Neutral or modest loss; consequences come from the fiction, not punishment.
Abandonment without cause	No reward; expenses may be denied.	Usually none; possible disciplinary review.	Loss of trust or Guild standing may follow.
Client breach	Guild escrow or reserve should protect the promised pay when possible.	Do not reduce earned QP.	The client, not the party, bears the reputational and legal consequence.

Failure Must Still Move the Campaign

- Reveal a cost, truth, new threat, changed relationship, or second chance rather than simply erasing the session's effort.
- Avoid retroactively redefining success because the party found an unexpected solution.
- Do not withhold promised rewards solely because the encounter felt easier than expected. The party may have prepared well or used a clever approach.

REWARD THE OBJECTIVE, NOT THE SCRIPT *A quest is complete when the real need is met under the agreed terms. Players are not required to follow the Dungeon Master's predicted method.*

11. DIVIDING REWARDS AND HANDLING INDIVIDUAL AWARDS

Party Coin and Saleable Treasure

The Guild default is equal division among participating adventurers after agreed common expenses, hiring shares, and restitution. The party may adopt another written method, but the Dungeon Master should ensure every player understands it and can raise concerns outside of character conflict.

Reward	Default Treatment
Contract coin	Divide equally among participating party members unless the contract specifies individual shares.
Quest Points	Award individually at the same base amount; do not pool or divide them.
Reputation	Apply to the party, individuals, or both according to who was known and responsible.
Permanent magic item	Assign by party agreement, clear narrative ownership, rotation, or a transparent method established before dispute.
Consumables	Place in a shared expedition pool or assign to the characters most able to use them.
Personal story reward	Belongs to the relevant character; it should not silently replace the whole party's promised contract reward.
Recovered valuables	Inventory first, settle ownership, then divide or sell only what may lawfully be claimed.

Hirelings, Retainers, and Allied NPCs

- Set wages, shares, risk premiums, and replacement obligations before departure whenever practical.
- Do not use allied NPCs to consume the party's reward without prior terms. If the Guild assigns support, the Guild should usually pay that support separately.
- An NPC who becomes a genuine party member may receive a full share, but this should be a table decision as well as an in-world agreement.

Individual Recognition

- Use medals, commendations, faction invitations, mentors, titles, or personal favors more often than unequal coin awards.
- An individual bonus should recognize a distinct responsibility or sacrifice, not compare players by damage, spotlight time, or the Dungeon Master's favorite scene.
- Private rewards may be appropriate for secret obligations, but avoid creating mechanical inequality that other players cannot understand or address.

PROTECT TABLE TRUST *Reward disagreements can become player disagreements quickly. Use transparent procedures for shared property and discuss the process outside the fiction when needed.*

12. LOOT, SALVAGE, EVIDENCE, AND CLIENT PROPERTY

Before placing valuables in an adventure, decide which ownership category applies. This turns accidental confusion into intentional choice and gives the Guild a consistent basis for disputes.

Category	Ownership Rule	Reward Treatment
Guild-issued property	Remains Guild property unless formally granted or written off.	Return, repair, or report loss; not divided as loot.
Client property	Belongs to the client or lawful owner.	May earn a recovery bonus; cannot be silently deducted from contract pay.
Evidence or dangerous material	Held for investigation, containment, or lawful authority.	Provide a handling fee, QP, reputation, or finder's award where suitable.
Lawful salvage	Unclaimed material from a site, creature, wreck, or defeated hostile force.	May be retained, sold, crafted, or surrendered under local law and contract terms.
Identifiable stolen property	Belongs to the victim or estate.	Returning it may earn reputation, finder's fee, or another quest.
Cursed, illegal, or restricted item	Possession may be dangerous or unlawful.	Treat safe recovery and disclosure as service; do not force use as the only reward.
Unclaimed treasure	No present owner can reasonably be established.	Divide under party procedure after taxes, claims, and Guild rules if any.

Monster Parts and Salvage

- Decide before the quest whether harvesting is possible, valuable, legal, culturally acceptable, and time-sensitive.
- Require an appropriate method, tool, check, or expert only when it creates meaningful play. Do not turn every defeated creature into a compulsory butchering mini-game.
- Preservation, transport, market demand, and contamination should matter more than a universal body-part price list.

Evidence and Chain of Custody

- Record who recovered the item, where it was found, who handled it, and whether it was altered or identified.
- The Guild should not punish the party for surrendering valuable evidence. Offer QP, reputation, compensation, or access that makes professional conduct feel worthwhile.

STATE SALVAGE RIGHTS ON THE NOTICE *A single sentence such as “ordinary salvage permitted after client property is recovered” prevents many disputes and creates clearer moral choices.*

13. REWARD PACING AND CAMPAIGN ECONOMY



A reward is healthy when it advances the campaign without making future decisions irrelevant. Before granting a major reward, test it against the five points of the balance wheel.

Pacing Questions

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Does this reward create progress without skipping a whole tier of play? | ☐ Will it solve a real problem rather than sit unused because it is too narrow or precious? |
| ☐ Does the party have a meaningful choice in how, when, or for whom it is used? | ☐ Will the players remember receiving it and understand why they earned it? |
| ☐ Does it connect to a person, place, faction, mystery, or consequence in the world? | ☐ What future reward remains exciting after this one? |

Common Reward Problems

Problem	Why It Hurts	Correction
Too much coin, no uses	Numbers rise but choices do not change.	Create meaningful services, projects, property, crafting, obligations, and investments.
Only combat power	Exploration, social play, and character identity receive less support.	Use mobility, information, tools, access, defense, utility, and faction benefits.
Every item is permanent	Capability accumulates faster than the campaign can respond.	Use consumables, charges, rentals, temporary boons, and situational assets.
Rewards are always secret	Players cannot judge risk or trust the contract.	Make promised terms explicit; keep surprise rewards additive.
Rewards depend on the planned solution	Creativity feels punished.	Reward objectives and consequences, not the expected script.
Unexplained inconsistency	The world feels arbitrary or unfair.	Make wealth, corruption, urgency, scarcity, or politics explain the difference.

CAMPAIGN LEDGER *Keep a simple record of major coin, QP, reputation, permanent items, property, and favors. Review it before preparing the next arc so rewards build on what the party actually values.*

14. WORKED EXAMPLES: GREEN AND YELLOW QUESTS

Orchard Stag - Green Classification

A large white stag repeatedly enters a northern orchard. It has attacked no one. The owner requests removal, and lethal action is prohibited.

Element	Prepared Reward
Primary objective	Determine why the stag returns: 5 gp total.
Protection term	No lethal action and no unnecessary damage to the orchard.
Conditional bonus	+3 gp if the party establishes a humane, lasting solution.
Guild award	1 QP per participating member.
Reputation	+1 with the orchard household or nearby farmers if the solution holds.
Hidden reward	A druid, fey, or local naturalist may offer information if the party recognizes the true cause.

DM NOTE *The low coin is appropriate because danger is not expected. The nonlethal restriction and mystery create the challenge; the hidden relationship reward points toward future play.*

Something Beneath Hollow Creek - Yellow Classification

Green light and repeated movement have been seen below the eastern bank after sunset. Two fishing lines were severed. No injuries are reported.

Element	Prepared Reward
Primary objective	Verified report: 10 gp total.
Escalation clause	Additional 10-25 gp if intervention is authorized after the party confirms the threat.
Expenses	Reasonable cost of specialized bait, rope, or waterproof light up to 5 gp.
Guild award	2 QP for a complete investigation; +1 QP if the party prevents imminent harm at meaningful risk.
Reputation	+1 with local fisherfolk for a clear warning and practical safety advice.
Salvage	Ordinary natural salvage permitted after evidence and affected property are documented.

DM NOTE *The two-stage contract prevents the Guild from paying combat rates before it knows whether there is a threat. It also lets the party return, report, and choose whether to accept a new risk.*

15. WORKED EXAMPLES: RESCUE AND HIGH-STAKES QUESTS

Missing Trapper - Yellow Classification

An elven trapper is overdue by two days from the western mushroom trail and carried only three days of food. No sign of attack is confirmed.

Outcome	Reward
Confirmed location only	5 gp total and 1 QP if the report is reliable and immediately useful.
Safe return	15 gp total and 2 QP per member.
Rescue under newly discovered major danger	Reclassify if appropriate; add 10-25 gp and consider +1 QP.
Recovered maps or critical warning	+1 reputation with local trappers or wardens; information may become a new quest.
Honest failure after meaningful search	Expenses may be covered; award partial QP for verified routes, signs, or prevention of further loss.

Ashglass Mine Evacuation - Orange, Silver-Rank Example

Element	Prepared Reward
Primary objective	Evacuate trapped miners and stabilize the primary exit: 500 gp.
Secondary objectives	+150 gp for all missing workers accounted for; +100 gp for preserving evidence of sabotage.
Modifiers	Remote site and hazardous air are included in the Orange classification; no duplicate modifier.
Guild award	3 QP; +1 QP for the evidence objective if it creates additional risk.
Reputation	+2 with the miners and +1 with the regional trade authority.
Treasure	Choice of one useful uncommon consumable package or one significant Guild service.
Failure handling	Partial pay and QP scale to lives saved, hazard contained, and intelligence returned.

Night of Broken Gates - Red, Gold-Rank Example

A city must hold three breached districts until civilians cross the inner river. The party is one element in a larger defense.

- Base contract: 12,000 gp, paid from city and Guild emergency funds.
- 5 QP per member, +1 for preserving the bridge controls, and +3 city reputation on success.
- Major reward: civic title, permanent access to the city's restricted archives, and a choice of one rare campaign-appropriate item from an approved source.
- Failure still pays according to civilians evacuated and districts held; the city's later condition becomes the consequence.

BLACK QUESTS *For Black-class operations, negotiate the coin only after deciding the world-level consequences. QP, sovereign favors, legendary access, unique relics, and the right to shape what survives matter more than a single price.*

16. QUEST NOTICE AND REWARD PREPUBLICATION CHECKLIST

Complete this review before the notice is posted or the patron makes a formal offer. Unknown answers may remain unknown in-world, but the Dungeon Master should understand which uncertainties are intentional.

Quest Definition

- ☐ The primary objective describes the real need, not a required method.
- ☐ Secondary, protection, time, discovery, and secret objectives are identified.
- ☐ The expected classification and eligible Guild ranks are recorded.
- ☐ The likely duration, travel, resupply, and retreat conditions are understood.
- ☐ The consequences of success, partial success, delay, and failure are prepared.

Reward Package

- ☐ The guaranteed coin amount and payer are established.
- ☐ Deposits, escrow, expenses, modifiers, and negotiation limits are established.
- ☐ Base QP, possible bonus QP, and reputation changes are recorded.
- ☐ Treasure, salvage rights, property ownership, and evidence handling are clear.
- ☐ Any favor, service, title, access, or hidden reward has usable limits.
- ☐ The reward leaves future rewards and future challenges meaningful.

Rules and Table Trust

- ☐ Official items and services have a verified physical sourcebook and rules version.
- ☐ Homebrew rewards are fully written and approved before they enter play.
- ☐ The party will know which terms are guaranteed, conditional, negotiable, or secret.
- ☐ The reward does not depend on following the Dungeon Master's predicted solution.
- ☐ The division process is clear enough to avoid an avoidable player dispute.

POSTING STANDARD *A quest notice may be mysterious about the danger. It should not be mysterious about the Guild's promise.*

Quick Award Reference

Class	QP	Common Reward Mix
Green	1	Small coin + QP or local reputation.
Yellow	2	Coin + QP + reputation, expenses, or a consumable.
Orange	3	Substantial coin + QP + reputation + service or treasure.
Red	5	Major coin + QP + strong faction consequence + arc-level reward.
Black	8+	Negotiated wealth + world-shaping access, favor, title, relic, or legacy.

17. QUEST REWARD WORKSHEET - PLANNING

Quest title: _____

Client or sponsor: _____

Questmaster / DM: _____

Eligible rank and level range: _____

Classification: _____

Objectives and Terms

Type	Objective or Term	Reward / Consequence
Primary		
Secondary		
Protection		
Time		
Discovery		
Secret DM term		

Reward Calculation - Core Terms

Component	Prepared Amount or Description
Base coin award	
Modifiers	
Guaranteed total	
Conditional bonuses	
Expense limit and method	
Base QP per member	
Bonus QP conditions	

PLANNING NOTE Complete the next page before the quest is posted. Hidden terms may remain unknown to the players, but they should not remain undefined for the Dungeon Master.

17. QUEST REWARD WORKSHEET - CONTINUED

Reward Calculation - Story and Property

Component	Prepared Amount or Description
Reputation gains or losses	
Treasure / item / sourcebook	
Service, favor, title, access, or information	
Salvage and ownership terms	
Payer, deposit, or escrow	
Negotiation limits	
Reclassification procedure	

Outcome Plan

Outcome	Payout and World Consequence
Complete success	
Partial success	
Honest failure	
Abandonment	
Client breach or false information	

Authorization

Reward approved by: _____

Date or session: _____

Special notes: _____

- ☐ Promised terms are clear enough to state at the table.
- ☐ The package leaves future rewards and challenges meaningful.
- ☐ Official rewards have a verified physical sourcebook and rules version.
- ☐ The contract rewards the objective rather than a predicted solution.

18. PAYOUT LEDGER AND POST-QUEST REVIEW

Quest title: _____

Date posted: _____

Date resolved: _____

Participating adventurers: _____

Recorded Payout

Entry	Awarded	Recipient / Holder	Notes
Contract coin			
Expense reimbursement			
Quest Points			
Reputation			
Permanent item			
Consumables			
Recovered property			
Favor or service			
Title, access, or authority			

Post-Quest Review

☐ Promised terms were honored or the breach became an explicit consequence.

☐ The party understands ownership of all recovered items and evidence.

☐ Quest Points and reputation were recorded in the campaign ledger.

☐ Permanent items, favors, property, titles, and access have written limits.

☐ The reward created at least one future choice, opportunity, obligation, or hook.

☐ Any precedent that should affect later contracts has been noted.

FINAL DM QUESTION *After the reward is paid, what will the players be excited to do with it? If there is no answer, the package may need more choice, story, or utility.*

THE QUESTMASTER'S FINAL MAXIMS

A reward closes one promise and opens another. Use these maxims when the numbers are uncertain, the client is unreliable, the party surprises you, or the most valuable thing in the room cannot be counted in coin.

PROMISE CLEARLY Mystery may hide the danger, but never use it to hide the terms already promised.	PAY THE REAL WORK Reward risk, responsibility, time, restraint, sacrifice, and outcome - not only combat.
PROTECT THE FUTURE A reward should expand play without making the next challenge or reward irrelevant.	RECORD THE DECISION Consistency becomes possible when the Guild remembers what it paid and why.
LET THE WORLD ANSWER Every reward should reveal who values the deed, who resents it, and what becomes possible next.	HONOR THE TABLE No treasure is worth undermining trust among the players or between the players and Dungeon Master.

THE FINAL STANDARD *Reward the deed, preserve the promise, and make the next choice more interesting than the last.*

Questmaster Sign-Off

Dungeon Master / Questmaster: _____

Campaign or chapter: _____

Effective date: _____



Authorized for Dungeon Master use by the Office of Contracts and Quest Administration.

Strength in Unity. Legacy in Action.